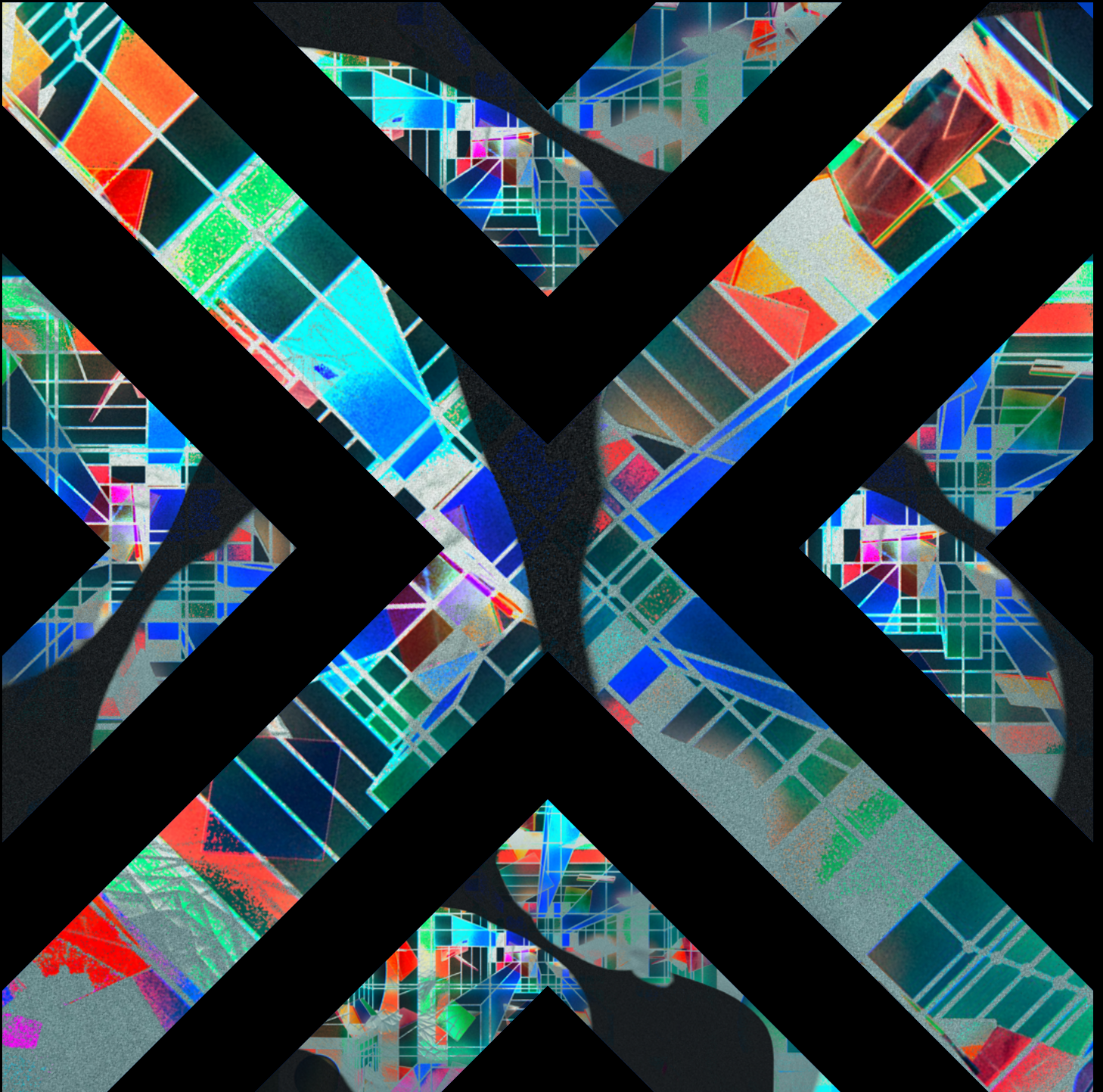


Have My Agent Call Your Agent:

NOVEMBER
2025

WINNING THE MACHINE-TO-MACHINE MARKETING FUTURE

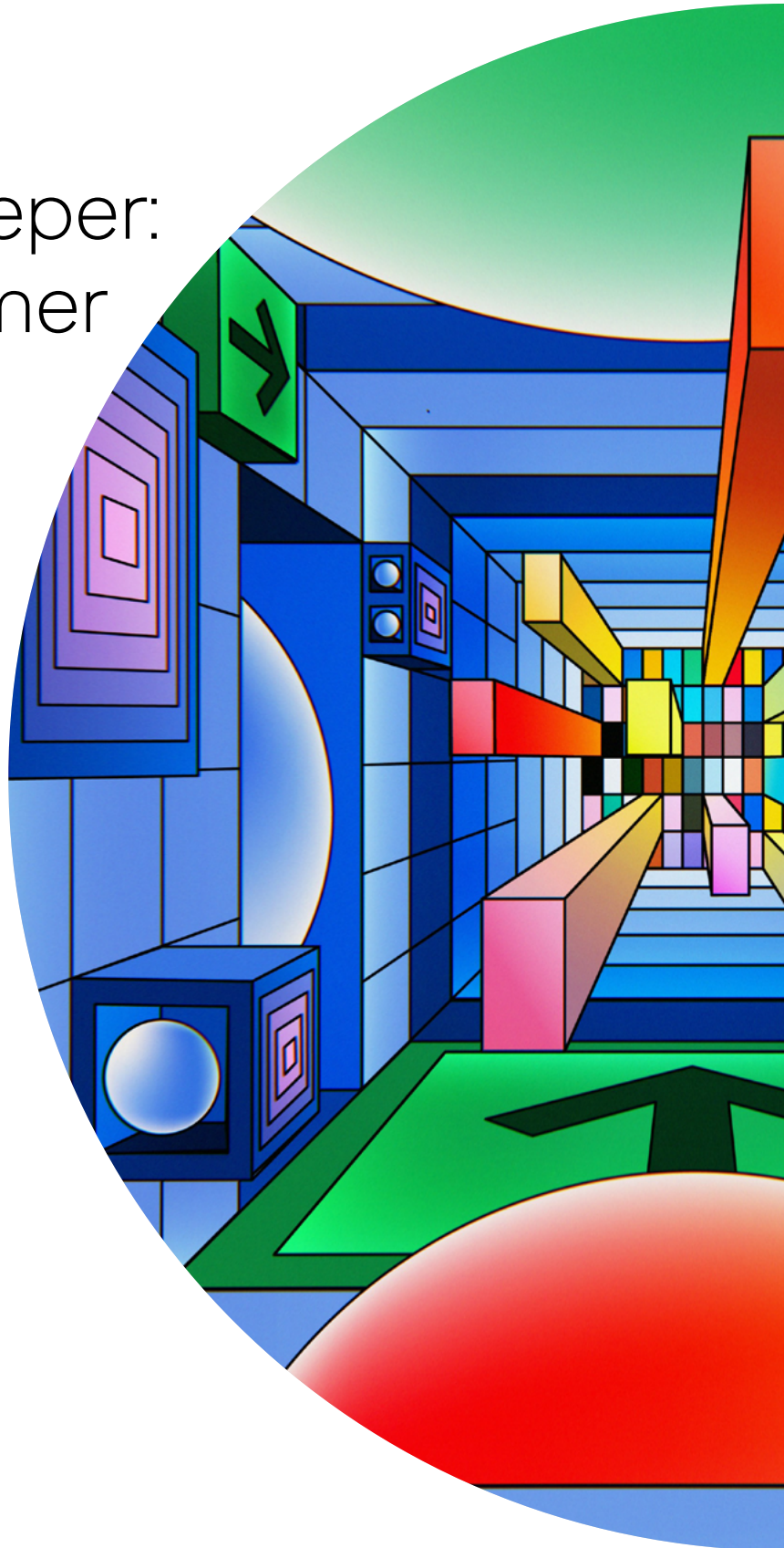


The New Gatekeeper: Your Next Customer Is An Algorithm

AI is exploding and companies are struggling to keep up with the exponential rate of change of the GenerativeAI Era. The next AI wave -- Agentic AI -- is about to reshape marketing, catalyzing the machine-to-machine (M2M) marketing era.

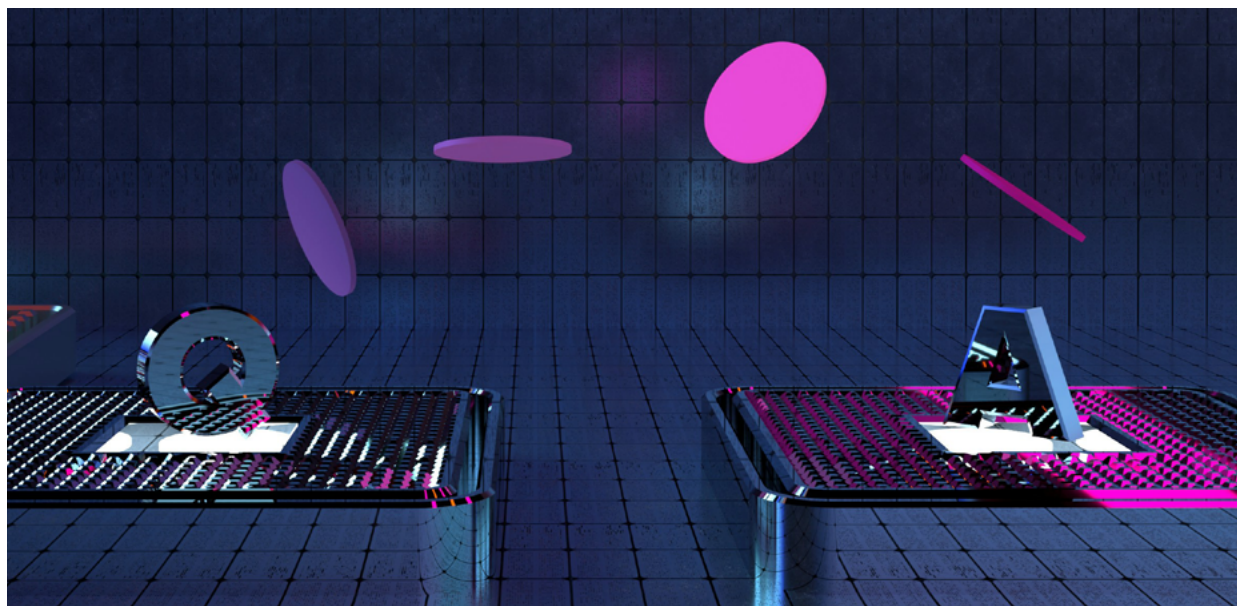
What does this mean? Agentic AI Assistants are quickly infiltrating brands' digital presence, establishing themselves as the interface to customer interactions and controlling their purchasing decisions.

During the golden era of Hollywood, you might have overheard the phrase "have your people call my people". As we enter the machine-to-machine Agentic AI era, proactive AI agents will disrupt how our audiences discover, shop, buy, live and work. The implication for marketers -- these Agentic AI Assistants and Algorithms are entering your target audience. Modern brands are already proactively rethinking their AI strategy and data stacks to identify when agents are at the digital front door to take back control of content, experience and data distribution.



Preparing for What's Next (Proactive vs Passive Agents)

We're in an explosive moment for AI and the language and terminology are still forming. Some LLMs are referred to as "agents," but they're actually prompt-and-response and passive from an experience standpoint. These models await your prompt and input to give you its response -- a predictive answer it statistically thinks best meets your needs.



Agentic AI is more proactive, operating on behalf of a consumer rather than waiting on specific commands. Agentic AI broadly refers to artificial intelligence systems designed to act autonomously, make decisions, and pursue goals based upon their directive and learned objectives.

While we're still at the early stages of consumer adoption, let's not forget that ChatGPT hit 1M users in five days, and reached 100M users within months of its launch. So, with the right use case and experience design, agentic AI adoption could occur in a flash and VML wants to ensure you are ready.



Most Companies Are Unprepared for the Agentic AI Era

Brands and companies are unprepared. Robots.txt, the de facto standard for web crawlers, is a remnant from the web 1.0 era. While they may still have a place for SEO today, this governance from 1994 is not sufficient to manage a brand's digital ecosystem in the agentic era. In the age of SEO, the rules were known – e.g., meta tags, sitemaps, canonical tags and structured data – gave organization, structure and clarity for search engines.

The recent introduction of llms.txt file is a half-step forward. This proposed standardized markdown file is designed to be a structured guide for LLMs to find and understand a site's most valuable content. It helps the models bypass some of the raw HTML, CSS or other irrelevant data that may clutter up the LLM's context window. But these tools are static by nature and do not allow for contextual control, based upon the dynamic, real-time needs of proactive AI agents.

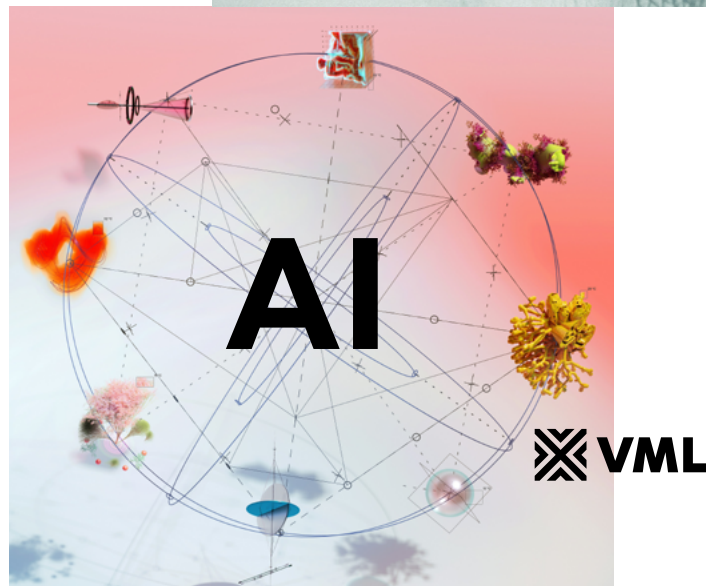
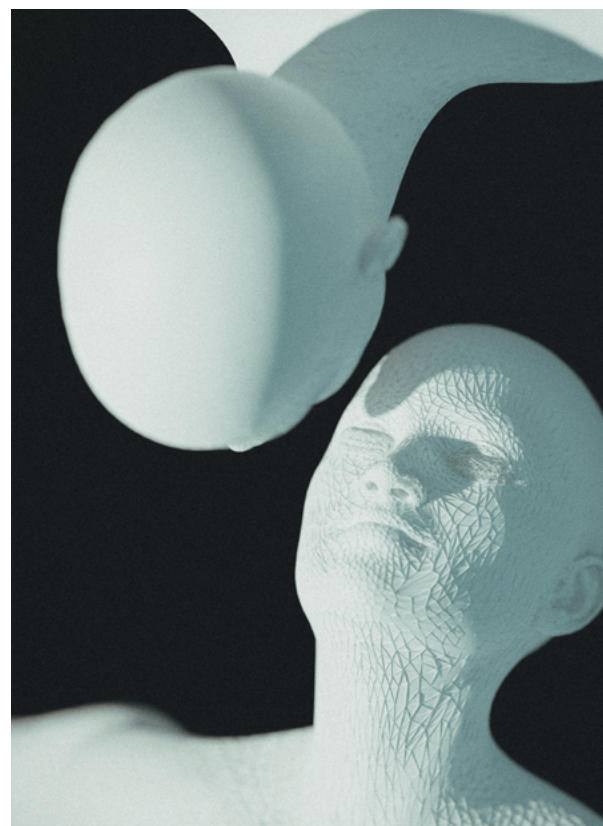
Brand Agentic Assistants Enable Agent-To-Agent Control

Brand Agentic Assistants will be the operational heart of machine-to-machine (M2M) communication. Brand Agents protect and optimize bot traffic to a brand, guiding the thousands of inbound agents to their destinations -- the right agents, APIs and data. It ensures efficiency and order, recognizes the friendly agents (consumer and partner agents) and fends off suspicious or malicious bots (data scrapers and competitors).

Robots.txt and llms.txt are static files -- typically rudimentary on/off switches that direct and allow access without the opportunity to understand the context of that customer.

The rise of the machines should enable better contextual control, both for consumers and brands, and Brand AI Agentic Assistants can proactively work to protect our interests, and provide data in exchange for value. When a personal or consumer agent calls the brand agent, it's not just requesting data, it's the start of a conversation or negotiation.

A Brand Agentic Assistant will allow for active, contextual management and control of brand data and content. This is the tip of the spear that defines the policies, permissions, and protocols for how any agent -- good or bad -- interacts with your brand's digital presence and gains access to a series of agents, content and datasets of a company.



"The rise of the machines should enable better contextual control, both for consumers and brands, and Brand AI Agentic Assistants can proactively work to protect our interests, and provide data in exchange for value."

Brand API: Designing an M2M Value Exchange

From a brand standpoint, this must force a set of questions specifically related to what data a brand should keep and what it wants to distribute and under what conditions. Below are a handful of questions to ask:

What data do we give in order to be visible in AIO/GEO (AI Optimization and Generative Engine Optimization)?

This discoverability inside of the models will be crucial as search volume moves from traditional search engines to LLMs.

What data/content do you want to require the consumer agent to provide and what do they get in exchange?

Location data to accurately represent nearby stores or inventory.

Past orders or content consumption – from your company and potentially from your competition to enable more personalized recommendation and offers or promotional pricing for switching.

User email or authentication to access loyalty program benefits and exclusive content or offers.

What content or experiences do you want to keep?

Sometimes brands may want to communicate to the agent and its human that some experiences are available, but you need to come to our site or store to see it. It may be something like a size accurate 3D model of a car to see how your kids will fit in the back seat of that car you're shopping for, or a high-touch experience in a retail store. Some experiences may be reserved for humans only.

Websites were designed and structured for people to access and read and click. But when it's an agentic assistant and not a person at your digital doorstep, the combination of a Brand Agentic Assistant and Brand API allow for the M2M exchange to be as fast and efficient as possible. Agentic assistants shouldn't have to scrape and "read" everything to solve for its objective. Brand API allows the brand to best manage and control the distribution of its content, data and experience distribution.

Human-First Checks and Balances

Reminder: The rise of the machines doesn't diminish the importance of the humans on the other side.

Marketers can often race to be first and forget the lessons of the past. As new channels emerge, the old ones haven't fully gone away. While search behaviors are shifting, there are still billions of searches each day that start from a traditional search engine and not an LLM or agent.

But when an ask starts with an agentic assistant or model, the importance of your brand name in that initial prompt is critically important. If you ask an agent to help you find "the best electric car for me" or the best Ford or Honda electric car, you'll get a dramatically different answer. Unless your strategy is to become a commodity, branding will still be crucial. And as time and attention with humans become more and more precious, brands should also apply AI to elevate and transform its customer experience.



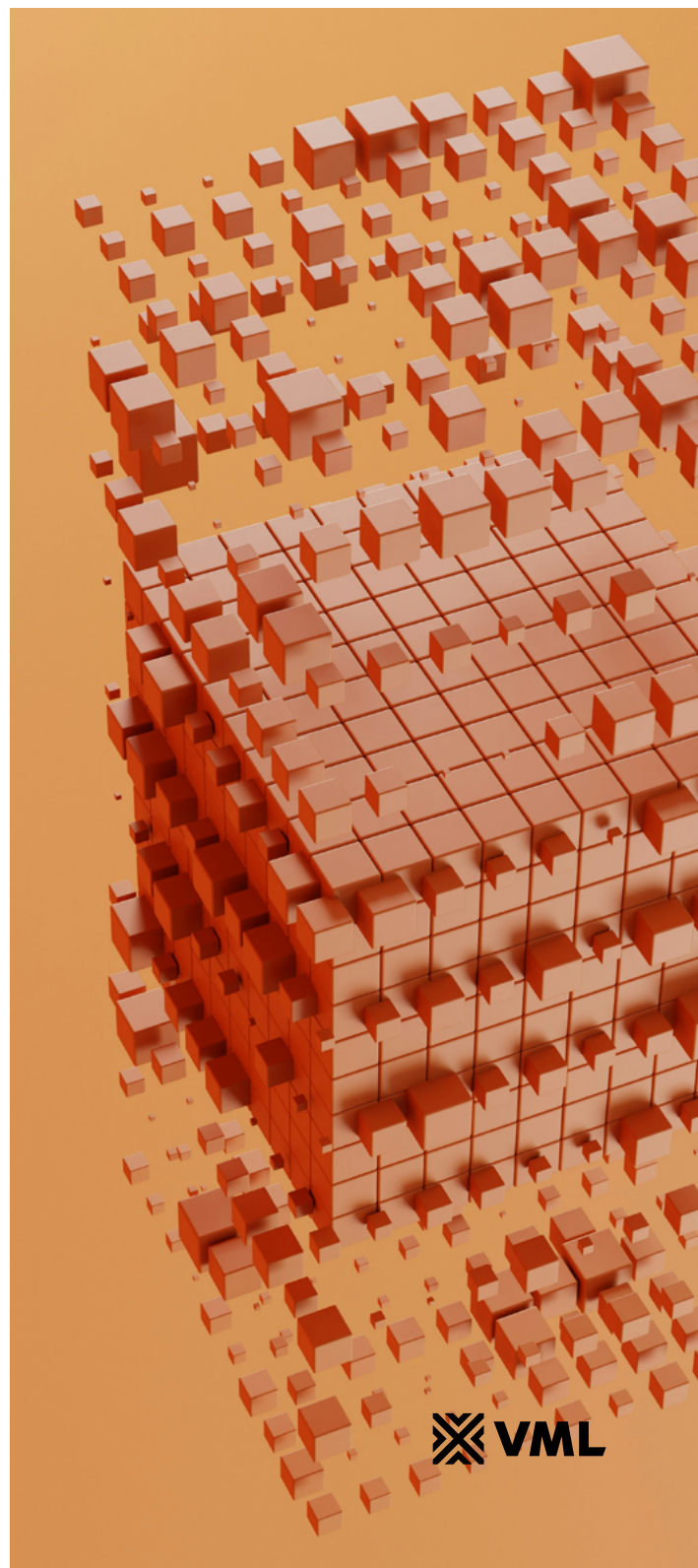
Three Takeaways and Actions for an M2M-Ready Enterprise

The transition to an M2M-native brand will not happen overnight. It requires a deliberate, phased approach that builds capabilities, demonstrates value, and manages risk. Attempting to build the entire Brand Agentic Framework and Brand API at once is a recipe for failure. Some foundational first steps:

1. Conduct an Agent Traffic Audit. You are already interacting with agents whether you know it or not. The first step is to make this visible. Examine your website analytics or deploy more advanced tools for bot detection to measure your web and app traffic. Get to a baseline of bot traffic today -- ideally segmenting search crawlers, friendly partner bots versus scrapers, social media bots, etc. Measurement frameworks and strategies need to evolve and are as important as ever.

2. Evaluate Your Data Readiness. Understand your customer-facing and internal data sources. Assess the state of your APIs. Are they modern, secure, and documented? Or a tangled mess. Enterprises have talked about cleaning up their mess of data for years, Agentic AI should finally be the catalyst that pushes companies to action.

3. Explore Internal Agentic POCs. Look inward first and identify 3-5 high-impact internal processes that are ripe for automation. Deploying agents to streamline these tasks will allow you to understand your capability and skills gaps, your data and tech readiness, and even begin to establish the ongoing operations and governance required to manage agentic systems. If you find the right internal use cases, you may also be able to find the efficiencies to fund new agentic development and growth.





Closing Thought

In this AI era, the winners won't be gridlocked with fear of moving forward. For those who don't, the risk isn't just stagnation, but obsolescence in a landscape where only the fittest survive. The good news, you don't need a massive budget or flawless plan to win. But in this era of near-constant change driven by AI, you do need to have an active curiosity, a growth mindset and the drive to get moving, continually evaluate, optimize and evolve.

VML helps clients build proactive Agentic AI strategies, including Brand Agentic Assistants and Brand APIs, to reclaim control, optimize discoverability, and more actively and contextually manage the exchange of content and data.

ABOUT VML

VML is a global brand creative and digital transformation company that combines brand experience, customer experience, and commerce, to create connected brands that drive growth. The agency is celebrated for its innovative and award-winning work with blue chip client partners including AstraZeneca, Colgate-Palmolive, Ford, Microsoft, Nestlé, The Coca-Cola Company and Wendy's. VML is recognized as a Leader by Forrester Wave™ reports for Commerce Services, Marketing, Creative and Content Services, and is a Strong Performer in the Forrester Wave™: CX Strategy, Consulting Services. It was also named a Leader in IDC MarketScape: Adobe Experience Cloud, Professional Services and a Visionary in the Gartner Magic Quadrant for Digital Experience Services. VML's specialist health network, VML Health, is also one of the world's largest and most awarded health agencies. VML's global network is powered by 26,000 talented people across 60-plus markets, with principal offices in Kansas City, New York, Detroit, London, São Paulo, Shanghai, Singapore and Sydney.

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